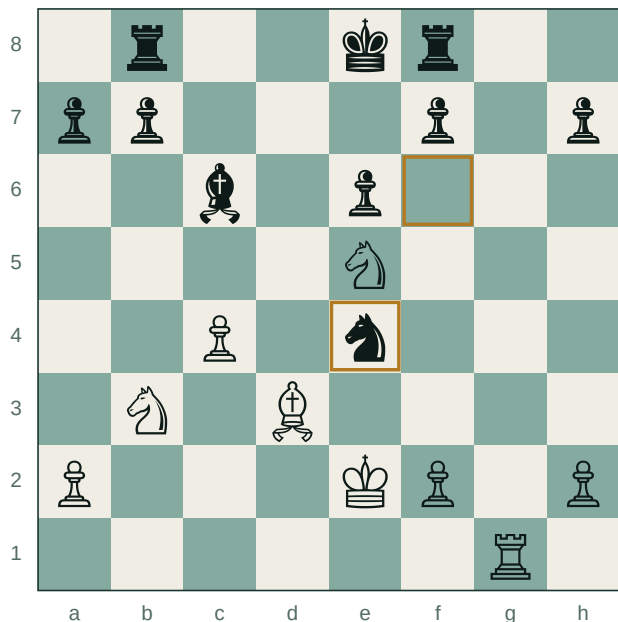


Capture the defender: White, move 22

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 21...Ne4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22. Nxc6 bxc6 23. Bxe4

22.Nxc6 The knight captures the bishop on c6. Recorded reply: **22...bxc6**.

23.Bxe4 The bishop captures the knight on e4.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -3 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on b8. Check for tactical protection.